



Three-peat show: P. V. Sindhu claimed her third title to join compatriot Saina Nehwal as the only three-time winner at the Syed Modi India International Super 300 tournament in Lucknow. SANDEEP SAXENA

SINDHU WON HER FIRST BWF WORLD TOUR TITLE SINCE JULY 2022 AFTER BEATING CHINA'S WU LUO YU IN THE WOMEN'S SINGLES FINAL

foreign player was Singapore's Jia Heng Jason Teh, ranked 39th in the world. Among the women, Pornpicha Choeikeewong of Thailand was the top-ranked foreign player at 48 in the world. While the former managed to reach the final before being dismantled by Lakshya in half an hour, the latter was knocked out early.

To be fair, the entries or interest from overseas players are neither the problem nor a concern for the Indians in the fray. They have had their own fair share of worries, of form, fitness and results haunting them all through the year, none

more than the two top seeds, who faltered on the biggest stage of all, the Paris Olympics.

While Sindhu was always an outsider to the medal prospects — she had last won a title at the 2022 Commonwealth Games and reached the final of a BWF Tour event only twice since then — Lakshya's

fourth-place finish was a big shock. The youngster was one of the medal favourites and lived up to the billing in the initial stages before losing from winning positions in knockouts, raising questions on his mental toughness from none other than coach and legend Prakash Padukone.

Although he was accompanied by